

Someone answers without a moment's hesitation, and you believe them because of it

8 findings · 10-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

The person who answers instantly isn't sounding sure because they checked more. **A tidy, confident answer and a correct one are two different things**, and the gap between them is where you get talked into the wrong pick.

THE GOAL

Pick between the two answers using what's specific and checkable in each, not how sure either person sounds while saying it.

CHECKLIST

The moment right after you've asked the same question twice, one answer came instantly and the other hedged, and you already feel yourself leaning toward the sure one.

- ☐ Ask the confident one to name the **fact that tipped it** for them, not just repeat their conclusion.
- ☐ Ask the hedging one exactly which part they're unsure about, not just whether they're sure overall.
- ☐ Push a follow-up question they haven't already answered, and line up how sure they sound on it against their original answer.
- ☐ If a harder follow-up doesn't make the confident one sound any less sure, count that against them, not for them.
- ☐ If you've asked the confident one things before, check whether you actually remember them being right last time, not just sure.
- ☐ If you can check either specific claim against a record, a number, or a source right now, do that before deciding.
- ☐ If you can't check it right now, write the specific claim down somewhere you'll actually see again, so you can check it later.
- ☐ Pick the answer that gave you **something specific enough to check**; if neither did, take whichever is easiest to undo if it's wrong.
- ☐ Say out loud, or write down, the one actual fact behind your pick, not "because they sounded sure."
- ☐ Put a date in your calendar to come back and check who actually turned out right, and note what you'll compare it against.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Certainty buys trust. The surer someone sounds, the less you actually check whether they're right, which is exactly backwards.
- 2** The higher someone's stated confidence climbs, the bigger the gap tends to grow between how right they sound and how right they actually are.
- 3** The moment you genuinely can't check who's right is **exactly when a confident answer gets believed**, whether or not it's true.

What their certainty is actually telling you

KNOW

Certainty buys trust. The surer someone sounds, the less you actually check whether they're right, which is exactly backwards.

People paid less attention to an adviser's track record the more confident that adviser sounded. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Someone arguing with total certainty can still mislead you into the wrong pick. It happens less often than a confident right answer winning, but it isn't rare enough to ignore.

Confident partners sometimes won the argument even while pointing at the wrong answer, with real money on the line. [Source 2](#)

WATCH

The higher someone's stated confidence climbs, the bigger the gap tends to grow between how right they sound and how right they actually are.

The gap between stated confidence and actual accuracy is shown to widen as stated confidence itself climbs higher. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

The reason someone sounds so sure is usually that they've built a tidy story with no loose ends in it, not that they checked more than you did.

A tidy story with no loose ends produces that feeling of sureness, and sureness like that is what earns belief from others. [Source 4](#)

What actually separates a checkable answer from a sure-sounding one

RULE

Someone who says they're 90 percent sure is, in typical calibration studies, only right about three times in four.

People's stated confidence regularly runs ahead of how often they turn out correct, across many kinds of questions. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

The moment you genuinely can't check who's right is **exactly when a confident answer gets believed**, whether or not it's true.

When there's no way to look up the answer afterward, confident advisers are shown to win out whether or not they're correct. [Source 1](#)

DO

Get the facts first. Settle on who's right only after that.

A disciplined, fact-first process is shown to serve complex decisions better than jumping straight to a gut call. [Source 4](#)

SAY

Ask them straight out: 'What's the specific thing that convinced you?' A repeat of what they already said doesn't count.

When a decision leaves room for reasons to be spelled out in words, sureness of tone alone carries a lot less weight. [Source 2](#)

Sources

1. <https://gspp.berkeley.edu/index.php/research-and-impact/publications/cheap-talk-and-credibility>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC6166527/>
3. [https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/biases/3_J_Experimental_Psychology_Human_Perception_552_\(Fischhoff\).pdf](https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/biases/3_J_Experimental_Psychology_Human_Perception_552_(Fischhoff).pdf)
4. <https://behavioralscientist.org/a-conversation-with-daniel-kahneman-about-noise/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Who to believe at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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